

FREE RESOURCE | 2026 EDITION

The Freelance Starter Kit 2026

Everything you need to launch, organize, and grow your freelance business

- + Freelance Launch Checklist
- + Rate-Setting Formula & Tables
- + Client Onboarding Checklist
- + Invoice Templates & Email Scripts
- + 7-Part Proposal Template
- + 10 Ways to Find Your First Client
- + Essential Tools List (2026)

18 Pages

FreelanceOS

baphometsblade.github.io/freelanceos-storefront

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FreelanceOS Pro

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How to use this kit: Print and check off each item as you go, or keep it open in a PDF reader. The rate formula and tools list are updated for 2026. Revisit whenever you're raising rates or onboarding a new client.

1. The Freelance Launch Checklist

Check off each item before pursuing clients. This is your launchpad — business setup, legal foundations, tools, and your first 30-day action plan.

BUSINESS SETUP

- ☐ Choose your business name (or use your real name)
- ☐ Create a professional email address (yourname@yourdomain.com)
- ☐ Open a dedicated business bank account
- ☐ Set up a simple portfolio website (even a one-pager works)
- ☐ Optimize your LinkedIn profile with your services and niche
- ☐ Write a 1-sentence description of what you do and who you help
- ☐ Define your target client: who, what industry, what size company
- ☐ Set your initial service offerings (1-3 specific services)

LEGAL FOUNDATIONS

- ☐ Create a standard freelance contract (or use a template)
- ☐ Decide on business structure: sole trader, LLC, or local equivalent
- ☐ Understand your local tax obligations (quarterly taxes, VAT, GST)
- ☐ Open a savings account for tax reserves (set aside 25-30% of income)
- ☐ Get a basic liability agreement for project work
- ☐ Research whether you need professional liability insurance

TOOLS SETUP

- ☐ Choose a project management tool (Notion, Asana, or Trello)
- ☐ Set up invoicing software (Wave is free; FreshBooks/HoneyBook for more)
- ☐ Choose a communication method for clients (email + Slack or Loom)
- ☐ Set up cloud storage for client deliverables (Google Drive or Dropbox)
- ☐ Create a template folder structure for client projects
- ☐ Set up time tracking if billing hourly (Toggl is free)
- ☐ Create proposal templates you can customize quickly
- ☐ Set up an e-signature tool (HelloSign free tier — 3 docs/month)

FIRST 30 DAYS — ACTION PLAN

Week 1: Foundation

- ☐ Complete all items in the Business Setup section above
- ☐ Write 10 names of people who might need or refer your services
- ☐ Post on LinkedIn about your freelance launch
- ☐ Set your minimum rate and your ideal target rate
- ☐ Create your first proposal template

Week 2: Outreach

- ☐ Send personalized messages to 5 people from your Week 1 list
- ☐ Reach out to 3 former colleagues or employers
- ☐ Post valuable content in 2 relevant online communities
- ☐ Apply to 3 relevant roles on Upwork or a freelance job board
- ☐ Ask 2 friends or former clients for referrals

Week 3: Systems

- ☐ Finalize your contract template
- ☐ Set up your invoicing workflow end-to-end with a test invoice
- ☐ Create a client welcome email template
- ☐ Build a project folder template to copy for each engagement
- ☐ Define your scope of work process to prevent scope creep

Week 4: Growth

- ☐ Review your outreach results — what worked, what did not?
- ☐ Follow up on outstanding proposals or conversations
- ☐ Schedule content posts for the next 2 weeks
- ☐ Identify 1 niche or service to double down on
- ☐ Set a revenue goal for the next 90 days

2. Setting Your Rates Formula

The biggest mistake new freelancers make is undercharging. Here is the formula and framework to set rates that reflect your value, cover your costs, and grow over time.

THE MINIMUM VIABLE RATE FORMULA

STEP	CALCULATION	EXAMPLE
1. Annual income goal	What you need to live + save	\$72,000
2. Billable hours/year	50 weeks x 25 hrs/week	1,250 hours
3. Overhead multiplier	Add 30% for taxes + expenses	x 1.30
4. Base hourly rate	Goal x Multiplier / Hours	\$74.88/hr
5. Your minimum rate	Round up + add profit margin	\$80/hr

Note: Only 25 billable hours/week sounds low, but it accounts for admin, marketing, unpaid revisions, and business development that comes with every project.

RATE RANGES BY EXPERIENCE LEVEL

Experience	Hourly Rate	Project Rate	Strategy
Beginner (0-1 yr)	\$25-\$50/hr	\$500-\$2,000	Build portfolio, get testimonials
Intermediate (1-3 yrs)	\$50-\$100/hr	\$1,500-\$8,000	Niche down, proven results
Advanced (3-5 yrs)	\$100-\$175/hr	\$5,000-\$20,000	Value-based pricing, retainers
Expert (5+ yrs)	\$150-\$300+/hr	\$15,000+	Consulting, equity, speaking

HOURLY VS. VALUE-BASED PRICING

	Hourly Pricing	Value-Based Pricing
Best for	Ongoing/unclear scope	Projects with measurable ROI
How to price	Time x rate	10-20% of value delivered
Pros	Simple, flexible	Earn more, rewards efficiency
Cons	Penalizes speed	Harder sell, needs proof
Example	\$80/hr x 20 hrs = \$1,600	Landing page = \$3,500 (drives \$30k revenue)

WHEN AND HOW TO RAISE YOUR RATES

Every 6-12 months	Raise 10-20% for existing clients. Give 30-60 days notice.
After a major win	Delivered strong results? Raise rates for all new clients immediately.
When fully booked	2+ week waitlist? Keep raising until demand equals capacity.
New niche or skill	Specialization commands a premium. Update rates immediately.
Scope creep moment	When a client asks for extras outside scope, use the new rate.

3. Client Onboarding Checklist

A smooth onboarding sets the tone for the entire relationship. Use this checklist for every new client.

PRE-KICKOFF (Before work begins)

- ☐ Contract signed by both parties
- ☐ Deposit invoice sent and paid (50% upfront is standard)
- ☐ Project brief or scope of work document completed
- ☐ Access credentials gathered (logins, brand assets, style guides)
- ☐ Project timeline agreed and documented
- ☐ Primary point of contact confirmed on client side
- ☐ Communication preferences agreed (email, Slack, response times)
- ☐ Kickoff call scheduled with agenda sent in advance

KICKOFF CALL AGENDA

- ☐ Welcome the client and set a positive tone
- ☐ Review project scope and timeline together
- ☐ Clarify any ambiguities in the brief
- ☐ Agree on revision rounds and feedback process
- ☐ Set up shared project folder or communication channel
- ☐ Confirm milestone dates and payment schedule
- ☐ Ask: What does success look like to you?
- ☐ Ask: Who are the stakeholders involved in approval?
- ☐ Ask: What is the approval process for deliverables?
- ☐ Send follow-up email summarizing what was discussed

WEEK 1 SETUP

- ☐ Create dedicated project folder with organized structure
- ☐ Add client to your project management system
- ☐ Set up recurring check-in calendar invite (weekly or bi-weekly)
- ☐ Send welcome package: process overview, how to give feedback
- ☐ Create first milestone task list and share with client
- ☐ Set up time tracking for the project if billing hourly

WEEKLY CHECK-INS

- ☐ Send progress update every Monday (even a 3-line email counts)
- ☐ Flag any blockers immediately — do not wait for the weekly call
- ☐ Document all client feedback in writing after verbal discussions
- ☐ Track hours or progress against milestones each week

FEEDBACK PROCESS

- ☐ Request all feedback in one round — not drip-by-drip
- ☐ Set a clear deadline for each feedback round
- ☐ If feedback contradicts the brief, raise it immediately
- ☐ Document approved deliverables in writing before moving on

SCOPE MANAGEMENT

- ☐ Log every request that falls outside the original scope
- ☐ Quote additional work as change orders, not extras you absorb
- ☐ Reference the original scope document when disputes arise

CLOSING THE PROJECT

- ☐ Final deliverables delivered and approved in writing
- ☐ Final invoice sent and paid
- ☐ Project folder handed over or access granted to client
- ☐ Offboarding call or wrap-up summary email sent
- ☐ Request testimonial or case study permission
- ☐ Ask for referrals to other potential clients
- ☐ Archive project files in your system

4. Invoice Best Practices

Getting paid on time starts with a professional invoice and clear payment terms. Here is everything you need.

ELEMENTS OF A PROFESSIONAL INVOICE

- [] **Invoice number:** Sequential (INV-001, INV-002) for easy tracking
- [] **Your business details:** Name, address, email, phone, tax/VAT number if applicable
- [] **Client details:** Client name, company, billing address
- [] **Invoice date:** Date issued — used for payment term calculations
- [] **Due date:** Write the actual date, not just NET 30
- [] **Line items:** Service description, quantity, rate, subtotal for each item
- [] **Tax:** Show applicable tax amount clearly
- [] **Total due:** Large, clear, prominent total
- [] **Payment methods:** Bank transfer details, PayPal, or Stripe link
- [] **Late fee policy:** e.g., 1.5% per month after due date
- [] **Notes or PO number:** Reference numbers, thank-you note, any special terms

PAYMENT TERMS GUIDE

Term	Meaning	Best For
Due on receipt	Pay immediately	Small amounts, new clients
NET 7	Pay within 7 days	Short projects, trusted clients
NET 15	Pay within 15 days	Most freelancers — recommended
NET 30	Pay within 30 days	Larger companies with AP teams
50/50 split	50% upfront, 50% on delivery	Most project work
Milestone-based	Pay at each project milestone	Long projects (3+ months)

LATE PAYMENT POLICY TEMPLATE

Invoices are due within [15/30] days of the invoice date. A late fee of 1.5% per month (or the maximum allowed by law) applies to overdue balances. Work may be paused on active projects until outstanding invoices are settled. Client agrees to these terms upon signing the project contract.

LATE PAYMENT FOLLOW-UP EMAIL SEQUENCE

Day of due date (if unpaid):

Hi [Name], friendly reminder that Invoice #[X] for \$[amount] is due today. Payment link: [link]. Let me know if you need anything.

3 days overdue:

Hi [Name], Invoice #[X] (\$[amount], due [date]) has not been processed yet. Could you confirm when to expect payment? Happy to help if there are any issues.

7 days overdue:

Hi [Name], Invoice #[X] is now 7 days overdue. Per our agreement, a late fee has been applied. Please process \$[new total] by [new date].

14+ days (final notice):

Hi [Name], final notice for Invoice #[X] (\$[total]), now [X] days overdue. If not received by [date], I will need to pursue formal collection. I would prefer to resolve this directly.

5. The Freelance Proposal Template

A great proposal wins work before the client talks to anyone else. Here is the 7-section structure that converts prospects into paying clients.

1. Executive Summary

Demonstrate you understand their problem before pitching your solution. Restate their goal in your own words. Example: "You want to redesign checkout to reduce cart abandonment — I have helped 3 similar SaaS companies reduce abandonment by 30-40%."

- ☐ Lead with their goal, not your bio
- ☐ Keep to 3-4 sentences
- ☐ Reference context from your discovery call

2. The Problem Statement

Articulate their problem better than they can. Show you have done your homework. This section builds trust — deep problem understanding signals solution capability.

- ☐ Use their data if available
- ☐ Be specific, not generic
- ☐ Show consequences of not solving it

3. Your Proposed Solution

Describe exactly what you will deliver and why your approach is right. Be specific about deliverables. Vague proposals lose to specific ones every time.

- ☐ List each deliverable clearly
- ☐ Briefly explain your methodology
- ☐ Connect solution back to their problem

4. Timeline and Milestones

Show a clear project plan. Clients need to see when things happen and when they provide input.

- ☐ Week-by-week or phase-by-phase breakdown
- ☐ Mark client review and approval points
- ☐ Include 20% buffer time

5. Investment (Pricing)

Never say cost — always say investment. If tiered, offer 3 options: clients usually choose the middle.

- ☐ Anchor high — present the premium option first
- ☐ Include payment terms
- ☐ Show what is NOT included to prevent scope creep

6. Why Work With Me

2-3 relevant case studies or testimonials. Not a full resume — just what is relevant to this client's problem.

- ☐ 1-2 sentences per case study with measurable results
- ☐ Match proof to their industry or problem
- ☐ Include logos if possible

7. Next Steps

Remove all ambiguity about what happens after they approve. A confused prospect does not convert.

- ☐ Clear call to action (reply to this email)
- ☐ Include contract and invoice info
- ☐ Set expiry date (proposal valid 7 days)

PROPOSAL DO'S AND DON'TS

DO	DON'T
+ Customize every proposal for the specific client	- Send generic templates without personalization
+ Lead with their goal and problem	- Open with your biography or credentials
+ Be specific about deliverables and scope	- Use vague language like 'various tasks'
+ Include a clear expiry date (7 days)	- Leave proposals open indefinitely
+ Follow up 3 days after sending	- Wait passively for them to respond
+ Present price as an investment	- Apologize for or justify your rates
+ Show relevant case studies and results	- Include irrelevant portfolio pieces

FOLLOW-UP SEQUENCE AFTER SENDING

Day 1 (send): Proposal sent. Brief warm email: 'I have sent over my proposal — happy to answer questions or jump on a call.'

Day 3 (if no reply): Gentle follow-up: 'Just checking in on the proposal I sent on [date]. Do you need additional information?'

Day 7 (if no reply): Final follow-up: 'I wanted to follow up one last time. I have space starting [date] — let me know if you would like to move forward.'

Day 14 (close the loop): Archive: 'I am going to close out this proposal. No hard feelings — I would love to work together in the future if timing works.'

6. 10 Ways to Find Your First Client

Here are 10 proven channels — ranked by difficulty, with realistic time-to-results estimates and actionable tips.

1. Warm Network Outreach

Difficulty: **Easy**

Time to results: **1-2 weeks**

Former colleagues, managers, classmates, and friends who know your work are 10x more likely to hire or refer you than a cold prospect.

- [] Message 20 people individually — not a mass email
- [] Tell them what you offer, who you help, and ask who they might know
- [] 'I'm now taking freelance web design clients — do you know any small businesses that need a new website?'

2. LinkedIn Outreach

Difficulty: **Medium**

Time to results: **2-4 weeks**

LinkedIn is the best B2B prospecting tool for freelancers. Your target clients are there.

- [] Headline: 'Freelance UX Designer for SaaS startups' — not just your job title
- [] Connect with 5-10 ideal clients daily with personalized requests
- [] After connecting: share value before pitching

3. Cold Email

Difficulty: **Hard**

Time to results: **4-8 weeks**

Cold email works if targeting is precise and the email is short, specific, and valuable.

- [] Target small businesses with obvious problems you can solve
- [] 3-4 sentences max: problem + proof + one ask
- [] Follow up 3 times, 3-5 days apart

4. Reddit + Online Communities

Difficulty: **Easy-Medium**

Time to results: **2-3 weeks**

Forums like r/entrepreneur and niche Slack groups have people asking for exactly what you offer.

- [] Identify 3-5 communities where your clients hang out
- [] Answer 10+ questions genuinely before mentioning your services
- [] Soft pitch: 'I actually do this professionally — happy to chat if helpful'

5. Upwork / Freelance Platforms

Difficulty: **Medium**

Time to results: **2-6 weeks**

Platforms have competition but also clients actively looking to hire right now.

- [] Niche your profile — generalist profiles do not convert
- [] Apply to jobs you are genuinely qualified for with customized proposals
- [] Get 3-5 reviews then raise rates and reduce platform dependence

6. Referral Program

Difficulty: **Easy (ongoing)**

Time to results: **Ongoing**

Referrals from happy clients are the highest-quality leads. Build an ask into every successful project.

- ☐ Ask: 'Who else do you know who might benefit from this?'
- ☐ Offer a referral bonus if appropriate
- ☐ Give them your one-liner and a sample message to share

7. Content Marketing

Difficulty: **Medium (slow burn)**

Time to results: **3-6 months**

Pick one channel — LinkedIn, X/Twitter, YouTube, or a newsletter — and commit to it.

- ☐ Post one piece of valuable content per week minimum
- ☐ Teach what you do: case studies, tips, behind-the-scenes
- ☐ Content compounds — slow ROI but enormous long-term payoff

8. Local Businesses

Difficulty: **Easy-Medium**

Time to results: **1-3 weeks**

Local businesses often need freelancers but do not know where to look.

- ☐ Email or visit 10-20 local businesses that could use your service
- ☐ Offer a free audit or assessment to get a meeting
- ☐ Chamber of Commerce events are underrated networking goldmines

9. Freelance Job Boards

Difficulty: **Easy**

Time to results: **1-3 weeks**

We Work Remotely, Contra, Toptal, and niche boards have less competition than Upwork.

- ☐ Apply to 5 positions daily with a specific cover letter
- ☐ Best boards: We Work Remotely, Contra, Remotive, Toptal, 99designs
- ☐ Personalized applications beat mass applying every time

10. Productized Services

Difficulty: **Medium**

Time to results: **4-8 weeks**

Package your most common service at a fixed price: 'I will design your landing page for \$997 in 5 days.'

- ☐ Identify the service you deliver most consistently
- ☐ Package it with fixed scope, price, and timeline

[] Market it as a product, not a custom engagement

7. Essential Freelance Tools List (2026)

Vetted, practical tools freelancers actually use. FREE = has a free tier you can start with today.

PROJECT MANAGEMENT

Tool	Price	Best For
Notion FREE	FREE / \$10/mo	All-in-one workspace for projects, notes, and client databases
Asana FREE	FREE / \$11/mo	Task and project tracking with team features
Trello FREE	FREE / \$5/mo	Kanban boards, great for visual project tracking
Linear FREE	FREE / \$8/mo	Best for dev-focused freelancers

INVOICING & ACCOUNTING

Tool	Price	Best For
Wave FREE	FREE	Free invoicing, accounting, and receipt scanning
FreshBooks	\$17/mo	Professional invoicing, time tracking, expenses
HoneyBook	\$16/mo	Client management + contracts + invoicing
Bonsai	\$21/mo	Invoices, contracts, proposals, time tracking for freelancers

CONTRACTS & E-SIGNATURES

Tool	Price	Best For
HelloSign (Dropbox Sign) FREE	FREE (3/mo)	E-signature — 3 free per month
DocuSign	\$10/mo	Industry standard e-signature tool
Bonsai Contracts	\$21/mo	Pre-built freelance contracts with e-sign
And.co (Fiverr) FREE	FREE	Contracts, proposals, invoices — free forever

COMMUNICATION & MEETINGS

Tool	Price	Best For
Slack FREE	FREE	Client communication — free for small teams

Loom FREE	FREE / \$15/mo	Screen recording for async client updates
Zoom FREE	FREE / \$14.99/mo	Video calls — free has 40-min group limit
Calendly FREE	FREE / \$10/mo	Scheduling links to eliminate back-and-forth

TIME TRACKING

Tool	Price	Best For
Toggl Track FREE	FREE	Simple, powerful time tracking with reports
Clockify FREE	FREE	Unlimited time tracking — generous free tier
Harvest FREE	FREE (2 projects)	Time tracking + invoicing with project budgets

PORTFOLIO & WEBSITE

Tool	Price	Best For
Carrd	\$19/yr	Simple one-page portfolio sites — easiest setup
Webflow FREE	FREE / \$14/mo	Professional no-code websites with CMS
Framer FREE	FREE / \$15/mo	Beautiful portfolio sites with animations
Notion + Super.so	\$12/mo	Turn your Notion into a public portfolio site

FILE STORAGE

Tool	Price	Best For
Google Drive FREE	FREE (15GB)	Cloud storage, sharing, and collaboration
Dropbox FREE	FREE (2GB)	File sharing and version control

PROPOSALS

Tool	Price	Best For
Bonsai	\$21/mo	Proposal creation with templates and analytics
Canva Docs FREE	FREE	Design-forward proposals in a familiar tool
Google Docs FREE	FREE	Simple professional proposals that get the job done

8. Next Steps with FreelanceOS

You now have the checklists, templates, and frameworks to launch your freelance business. But checklists alone do not build a business — systems do.

FreelanceOS Pro is the Notion system built to run everything in this kit — and 50+ more workflows — automatically, in one workspace.

WHAT IS INSIDE FREELANCEOS PRO

Client CRM	Track every client, project status, and communication history
Project Manager	Kanban + timeline view with milestones and task tracking
Invoice Tracker	Log invoices, track paid/unpaid, calculate outstanding balance
Proposal Templates	7 pre-built proposal templates ready to customize
Financial Dashboard	Monthly revenue, expenses, profit, and tax reserve tracker
Contract Templates	Pre-written contracts for common freelance engagements
Onboarding System	Client onboarding workflow — automated and repeatable
Weekly Review	Built-in weekly business review to stay on top of goals
Goal Tracker	90-day goal system tied to revenue and project milestones
Content Hub	Plan and track your content marketing and outreach

ALL PRODUCTS

Product	Price	Description	Badge
FreelanceOS Pro	\$49	Complete freelance business system	<i>Most Popular</i>
CreatorHQ	\$39	Content creation and brand management for creators	
AgencyOS	\$49	Agency operations, client delivery, team management	
YouTube Empire	\$29	YouTube channel growth system with analytics tracker	

EXCLUSIVE OFFER — Use code FLASH40 for 40% off any product.

Get FreelanceOS Pro for just \$29.40 — the complete Notion system behind everything in this kit.

Visit: baphometsblade.github.io/freelanceos-storefront

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